

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Vehicle breakdown

VEHICLE TRAVEL / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move out of traffic if you safely can, switch on hazard lights and call roadside assistance or emergency services for immediate danger. Give your road, direction and nearest marker. On a high-speed road, follow local road-authority advice about whether to stay belted inside or exit to a protected area.

Do now.

**Protect from traffic**

01

Do not stand in travel lanes or between vehicles. Avoid repairs beside moving traffic.

**Give a precise location**

02

Share the road name, direction, marker and number of people.

**Assess immediate danger**

03

If fire, smoke or a collision threat makes the vehicle unsafe, move to a safe location away from traffic when possible.

**Wait safely**

04

Keep children and pets protected and conserve phone power. In remote areas do not wander without a known safe destination.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Record your exact location, stay visible without standing in traffic and conserve your phone. Do not begin walking along a dangerous road or into remote terrain without a known reachable refuge. In heat or cold, watch occupants closely and reassess whether the vehicle remains safe.

Watch for.

Exit choices depend on the road and surroundings; do not apply one universal rule to every breakdown.

People & practical needs.

Count occupants, monitor temperature and keep children away from traffic. Preserve medicines, water and a light within reach. Do not split the group without a clear safe destination and a reliable way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: protect from traffic. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Exit choices depend on the road and surroundings; do not apply one universal rule to every breakdown.

Keep essentials within reach.

For vehicle breakdown, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Record your exact location, stay visible without standing in traffic and conserve your phone. Do not begin walking along a dangerous road or into remote terrain without a known reachable refuge. In heat or cold, watch occupants closely and reassess whether the vehicle remains safe. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Carry water, weather protection, a charged phone and a vehicle kit. Check tires, fuel or charge before travel.

First decision: Protect from traffic

Do not stand in travel lanes or between vehicles. Avoid repairs beside moving traffic. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Record your exact location, stay visible without standing in traffic and conserve your phone. Do not begin walking along a dangerous road or into remote terrain without a known reachable refuge. In heat or cold, watch occupants closely and reassess whether the vehicle remains safe. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Exit choices depend on the road and surroundings; do not apply one universal rule to every breakdown. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Move out of traffic if you safely can, switch on hazard lights and call roadside assistance or emergency services for immediate danger. Give your road, direction and nearest marker. On a high-speed road, follow local road-authority advice about whether to stay belted inside or exit to a protected area. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For vehicle breakdown, keep the specific hazard in view: Exit choices depend on the road and surroundings; do not apply one universal rule to every breakdown.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Wait safely. Keep children and pets protected and conserve phone power. In remote areas do not wander without a known safe destination. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Vehicle breakdown · official guidance

<https://www.nhtsa.gov/road-safety>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/vehicle-breakdown/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.